

Personal Finance and Investing Fundamentals Cheat Sheet

16 tables · 116 concepts · Updated 2026-08-01 · cheatgrid.com

Personal finance and investing fundamentals form the foundation of **long-term financial security and wealth building**. Understanding core concepts like budgeting, compound interest, asset allocation, and tax-advantaged accounts enables informed decisions that compound over decades. The key insight that separates successful wealth builders from others is that **consistent habits matter far more than perfect timing**: staying invested, living below your means, and letting compound growth work over time delivers better results than chasing market trends or waiting for the "perfect" moment to start. This sheet is the map of the whole territory; for a deeper dive into budgeting mechanics, insurance, employer retirement plans, IRAs and HSAs, or building a first portfolio, see CheatGrid's dedicated cheat sheets on each.

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TABLE 1

Budgeting Methods

A budget is just a plan for where your money goes before it arrives, and the method matters less than whether you'll actually stick with it. These approaches span loose percentage splits like the 50/30/20 rule to the hands-on discipline of zero-based or envelope budgeting, plus the "save first, spend the rest" family of methods. Pick the one that matches how much friction you're willing to tolerate; for day-to-day tracking tools and a deeper debt playbook, see CheatGrid's Personal Budgeting and Debt Management cheat sheet.

Method	Example	Description
50/30/20 Rule	50% needs, 30% wants, 20% savings	• Allocate 50% of after-tax income to necessities (housing, food, utilities), 30% to discretionary spending, and 20% to savings and debt repayment • simple framework ideal for beginners, but treat the split as a flexible starting point since needs commonly run above 50% in high cost of living areas.

Method	Example	Description
Zero-Based Budgeting	Income \$5,000 minus every assigned expense and savings goal equals \$0	• Every dollar gets a specific job (spending, saving, or debt payoff) until income minus assignments equals zero • does not mean spending it all: savings and debt payments are categories too, so forgetting that is the most common misunderstanding of the method.
Envelope Method	Cash in labeled envelopes: \$400 groceries, \$200 dining	• Divides discretionary, variable spending into cash filled envelopes by category • when an envelope is empty, spending in that category stops • best kept for categories that swing month to month; fixed bills like rent or phone still go through electronic bill pay, not an envelope.
Pay Yourself First (Reverse Budgeting)	Auto-transfer 20% of each paycheck to savings, then spend the rest	• Savings and investing get moved out the moment you're paid, ahead of any bill or purchase • also called reverse budgeting because it flips the usual order: you spend whatever's left, instead of saving whatever's left • skips detailed expense tracking, but works best with steady income since irregular paychecks can force money back out of savings.
70/20/10 Rule	70% spending, 20% savings, 10% extra debt payoff or giving	• Allocates 70% to everyday spending (needs and wants combined, including minimum debt payments), 20% to savings and investing, and 10% to extra debt payoff or charitable giving • simpler than 50/30/20 since it does not require separating needs from wants.

TABLE 2

Financial Order of Operations

Once a budget frees up cash, the next question is which account or debt gets that dollar first, and a few well-known frameworks answer it in slightly different orders. All three below agree on the big moves (cover your safety net, capture free money, kill high-interest debt) but disagree on the exact sequence and how aggressively to save afterward. Treat any of them as a starting checklist, not a rigid law: a new baby, a layoff, or a market crash routinely bumps you between steps.

Framework	Example	Description
Financial Order of Operations (FOO)	Deductibles covered → employer match → high-interest debt → 3-6 month emergency fund → Roth IRA/HSA → max employer plans → bigger goals	• Nine-step sequence from the Money Guy Show that prioritizes the employer match before paying off high-interest debt • targets investing 25% or more of income once the early steps are done.
Dave Ramsey's 7 Baby Steps	\$1,000 starter fund → debt snowball → 3-6 month fund → invest 15% → kids' college → payoff home early → build wealth	• Debt-first sequence: pays off all non-mortgage debt via the snowball method before any investing resumes, even the employer match • more conservative savings target (15%) than the FOO's 25%.
r/personalfinance Prime Directive	Community flowchart, revised for 2026	• Crowd-sourced flowchart that, like the FOO, prioritizes a small starter fund and the employer match early • a free, non-commercial alternative maintained by the subreddit's moderators rather than tied to a book or course.

TABLE 3

Saving and Emergency Funds

Before investing makes sense, you need a cash cushion that keeps a surprise expense from turning into high-interest debt. These concepts cover how big that cushion should be, where to park it for both safety and yield, and the two numbers, your savings rate and net worth, that tell you whether the rest of your plan is actually working.

Concept	Example	Description
Emergency Fund	6 months expenses = \$18,000	• Liquid savings covering 3-6 months of essential living expenses • protects against job loss, medical emergencies, or major repairs without resorting to high-interest debt.
Starter Emergency Fund	Initial \$1,000 saved	• Minimum \$1,000 buffer for immediate emergencies • achievable first milestone that prevents small crises from becoming debt spirals while building larger fund.

Concept	Example	Description
High-Yield Savings Account	4.5% APY vs 0.5% traditional	- FDIC-insured account paying significantly higher interest than traditional savings - ideal for emergency funds combining accessibility with better returns.
Savings Rate	Save 20% of \$60,000 = \$12,000/year	Percentage of income directed to savings, including retirement contributions like a 401(k) - widely used guidelines run from about 12-15% up to 20-25% of pay depending on age and how late you started, with higher rates speeding up financial independence.
Net Worth Tracking	Assets \$250K - Liabilities \$80K = \$170K	Total assets minus total liabilities - primary metric for measuring overall financial health and progress toward wealth-building goals over time.

TABLE 4

Tax-Advantaged Retirement Accounts

The single biggest lever most people have is *which account* they invest through, because the tax treatment compounds alongside the returns over decades. The core distinction here is timing: traditional accounts deduct now and tax later, while Roth accounts tax now and grow tax-free forever. The HSA, 529, and backdoor strategies layer on top for specific situations and high earners; CheatGrid's dedicated 401(k) match and IRA/Roth/HSA cheat sheets go much deeper on choosing between them.

Type	Example	Description
Traditional 401(k)	Contribute \$10,000 pre-tax, reduce taxable income	- Employer-sponsored plan with pre-tax contributions that lower current taxable income - taxes paid upon withdrawal in retirement - often includes employer matching.
Roth 401(k)	Contribute \$10,000 after-tax, withdraw tax-free	- After-tax contributions to employer plan with tax-free qualified withdrawals - no income limits 2026 limit \$24,500 + \$8,000 catch-up ages 50-59, \$11,250 catch-up for ages 60-63.
Traditional IRA	Deduct \$7,500 contribution from taxable income	- Individual account with tax-deductible contributions; if covered by a workplace plan, the 2026 deduction phases out \$81,000-\$91,000 single, \$129,000-\$149,000 married filing jointly - taxes owed on withdrawals 2026 limit \$7,500 + \$1,100 catch-up.
Roth IRA	After-tax \$7,500 grows tax-free forever	- After-tax contributions with completely tax-free growth and withdrawals 2026 income phase-out \$153K to \$168K single, \$242K to \$252K married - ideal for young investors expecting higher future tax rates.
Backdoor Roth IRA	Contribute \$7,500 to Traditional IRA, immediately convert to Roth	- Strategy for high earners exceeding Roth income limits - contribute to non-deductible Traditional IRA, then convert to Roth - watch the pro-rata rule if you hold other pre-tax IRA money.
Mega Backdoor Roth	After-tax 401(k) contributions up to \$72,000 total	- Advanced strategy allowing up to \$72,000 combined 2026 contributions (higher with catch-up) through after-tax 401(k) contributions and in-plan conversions - requires employer plan support.
HSA (Health Savings Account)	\$8,750 family contribution, triple tax advantage	Triple tax benefit: deductible contributions, tax-free growth, tax-free withdrawals for qualified medical expenses 2026 limits \$4,400 self-only / \$8,750 family; balances roll over every year, unlike an FSA - after 65, non-medical withdrawals owe income tax but skip the 20% penalty.
529 Plan	\$19,000/year per beneficiary, tax-free for education	- State-sponsored plan for tax-free education savings - contributions grow tax-deferred, withdrawals tax-free for qualified education expenses including up to \$20,000/year in K-12 tuition (2026) - leftover funds can roll into the beneficiary's Roth IRA under SECURE 2.0, up to a \$35,000 lifetime cap.
SEP IRA	Self-employed contribute up to 25% of income	- Simplified Employee Pension for self-employed and small business owners - employer contributions up to the lesser of 25% of compensation or \$72,000 (2026) - no catch-up or elective deferral option, but easier administration than a solo 401(k).

TABLE 5

Investment Vehicles

Once money is in an account, these are the actual things you can buy with it, arranged roughly from highest risk and effort to safest and simplest. Knowing the trade-offs, individual stocks for concentrated bets, index funds and ETFs for cheap diversification, bonds and CDs for stability, lets you assemble a portfolio that fits your timeline instead of chasing whatever's popular. CheatGrid's Investing 101 cheat sheet builds these into a full first portfolio, step by step.

Vehicle	Example	Description
Individual Stocks	Buy 100 shares of NVDA at \$900	• Ownership shares in single companies • potential for high returns but concentrated risk • requires research and monitoring • suitable for experienced investors.
Bonds	\$10,000 10-year Treasury at 4.1% yield	• Debt securities paying fixed interest • lower risk than stocks • provide income and portfolio stability • inverse relationship with interest rates.
Mutual Funds	VFIAX tracks S&P 500, \$10K minimum	• Pooled investments professionally managed • buy at end-of-day NAV • active management typically has higher fees • suitable for hands-off investors.
ETFs (Exchange-Traded Funds)	VOO S&P 500 ETF, 0.03% expense ratio	• Basket of securities trading like stocks • typically lower fees than mutual funds • trade throughout the day • tax-efficient structure.
Index Funds	FXAIX S&P 500 index, passive tracking	• Mutual funds or ETFs tracking market indexes • ultra-low fees • over the long run, most active large-cap managers fail to beat the index • ideal core holding.
REITs (Real Estate Investment Trusts)	VNQ real estate ETF, 4.3% dividend yield	• Companies owning income-producing real estate • required to distribute 90% of income as dividends • provide real estate exposure without property management.
Target-Date Funds	Vanguard Target 2050 Fund	• Automatically rebalances from aggressive to conservative as target retirement date approaches • single-fund solution reducing equity allocation over time.
Money Market Funds	VUSXX yielding 4.5%, \$1 stable NAV	• Ultra-safe cash-equivalent investments in short-term debt • stable \$1 share price • higher yields than savings accounts • not FDIC insured, unlike a bank money market account.
Certificates of Deposit (CDs)	5-year CD at 4.5% APY, FDIC-insured	• Fixed-rate time deposits with guaranteed returns • FDIC insurance up to \$250K • penalties for early withdrawal • ladder strategy provides liquidity.
I Bonds (Inflation-Protected)	\$10,000/year limit, adjusts with inflation	• U.S. Treasury bonds with rates tied to inflation • 30-year maturity, cashable after 1 year (penalty before 5 years) • \$10K annual purchase limit protects purchasing power.
Annuities	SPIA pays \$500/month for life starting age 65	• Insurance products providing guaranteed income streams • fixed, variable, or indexed, listed in order of increasing risk • immediate or deferred payouts • suitable for longevity risk management.

TABLE 6

Investment Asset Allocation

Allocation (the split between stocks, bonds, and other assets) drives far more of your long-term result than picking individual winners. These strategies give you different ways to decide that mix, whether you anchor it to your age, a fixed 60/40 ratio, your personal risk tolerance, or a glide path that grows more conservative as retirement approaches. CheatGrid's Investing 101 cheat sheet covers building and rebalancing an actual portfolio around one of these.

Strategy	Example	Description
Age-Based Allocation	Age 30: 110 - 30 = 80% stocks	- Formula 110 minus age estimates a starting stock percentage - you recalculate and apply it yourself as you age, it does not shift on its own like a glide path - a generic baseline that ignores your risk tolerance, other income, and specific goals.
60/40 Portfolio	\$100K: \$60K stocks, \$40K bonds	- Traditional balanced allocation combining growth and stability 60% equities for returns, 40% bonds for income and typically lower volatility - still carries real risk, in 2022 stocks and bonds fell together and the mix lost about a quarter of its value.
Three-Fund Portfolio	U.S. stocks 60%, international 20%, bonds 20%	- Bogleheads approach using total market, international, and bond index funds - complete diversification with minimal complexity and ultra-low costs.
Asset Location	Bonds in IRA, stocks in taxable account	Placing tax-inefficient assets (bonds, REITs) in tax-deferred accounts - hold tax-efficient assets (index funds) in taxable accounts - a separate decision from asset allocation, historically estimated to add roughly a few tenths of a percent up to about 0.75% in annual after-tax return, depending on the study.
Glide Path	Stocks: 80% age 30 → 40% age 70	Predetermined reduction in risk over time, built into the fund itself - automatically shifts from growth-focused to income-focused as retirement nears - used in target-date funds, unlike a formula you apply yourself.
Risk-Based Allocation	Aggressive: 90% stocks, Moderate: 60%, Conservative: 30%	- Portfolio mix based on risk tolerance and risk capacity rather than age - risk tolerance is how comfortable you are with volatility, risk capacity is how much of a loss your timeline and income can actually absorb.
Core-Satellite	80% index funds (core) + 20% individual stocks (satellite)	Majority in low-cost index funds (the core) for stability - smaller allocation (the satellite) to active picks or specialized strategies for potential outperformance.

TABLE 7

Compound Interest and Time Value

Compounding is the engine behind every wealth building plan: money earns returns, and those returns earn returns of their own, so time in the market matters more than almost anything else. These concepts give you mental shortcuts, like the Rule of 72 and dollar-cost averaging versus lump sum, to reason about that growth without needing a spreadsheet.

Concept	Example	Description
Compound Interest	\$10K at 8% = \$21,589 in 10 years	- Interest earned on both principal and accumulated interest - exponential growth over time - works against you the same way on debt, like credit cards, since unpaid interest compounds too - often attributed to Einstein as "the eighth wonder of the world," though there's no evidence he ever said it.
Rule of 72	72 ÷ 8% return = 9 years to double	- Quick estimation: 72 divided by annual return approximates years to double investment 72 ÷ 6% = 12 years - a handy approximation, most accurate for returns roughly between 6% and 10% - also works for estimating how fast debt doubles at a given interest rate.

Concept	Example	Description
Time Value of Money	\$100 today > \$100 in 1 year	- Money available now is worth more than an identical future sum, mainly due to the opportunity cost of not being able to invest it right away - distinct from inflation, though inflation adds to the effect - foundation for present value and future value calculations in investing.
Dollar-Cost Averaging	Invest \$500/month regardless of price	Fixed amount invested at regular intervals - reduces the emotional risk of bad timing - psychologically easier than investing a lump sum all at once - historically underperforms lump sum investing roughly two-thirds of the time, since it usually means less time in a rising market.
Lump Sum Investing	Invest \$50,000 immediately	- Deploy the entire sum immediately rather than gradually - more time in the market to compound tends to beat waiting to time an entry point - historically outperforms dollar-cost averaging roughly two-thirds of the time but requires comfort with short-term volatility.
Annual Compounding Frequency	\$10K at 10% for 1 year: quarterly compounding grows to \$11,038, daily to \$11,052	More frequent compounding increases returns, at least a little - daily compounding yields slightly more than quarterly or monthly, but the gap shrinks as frequency increases - impact is more pronounced at higher interest rates and over longer timeframes.

TABLE 8

Debt Payoff Strategies

High-interest debt is compound interest working against you, so clearing it is often the best "investment" you can make. The central choice is avalanche versus snowball (fastest savings versus fastest motivation), and the rest of these tools, from balance transfers to consolidation, mostly buy you a lower rate while you do the work. CheatGrid's Personal Budgeting and Debt Management cheat sheet covers the day-to-day mechanics of building and sticking to a payoff plan.

Method	Example	Description
Debt Avalanche	Pay minimums, extra \$500 to 18% APR card	Highest interest rate first - mathematically optimal approach saving the most money - psychologically harder since high balances can take longer to clear.
Debt Snowball	Pay minimums, extra \$500 to smallest balance	Smallest balance first regardless of interest rate - quick wins build psychological momentum - the motivation boost often outweighs its higher total interest cost.
Balance Transfer	Move \$10K to 0% APR for 18 months	- Move high-interest debt to a promotional 0% APR card - pauses interest for a fixed window, typically 12 to 21 months - usually carries a 3 to 5% upfront transfer fee and reverts to a high rate once the window ends.
Debt Consolidation Loan	Combine \$30K credit cards into 8% loan	- A single lower-rate loan replacing multiple debts - simplifies payments and can lower total interest - doesn't fix the spending habits that caused the debt, so old cards can get run up again.
Minimum Payment Trap	\$1,000 at 13% APR, 2% minimum payment (\$20)	- The CARD Act requires a warning box on statements showing this cost - on this example, roughly \$11 of the \$20 goes to interest, leaving about \$9 to reduce the balance - paying only minimums can stretch payoff across years and multiply total interest.
Refinancing	\$200K mortgage 6% to 4.5% saves \$185/month	- Replace an existing loan with better terms or a lower rate - the break-even point is closing costs divided by monthly savings - resetting the loan term can raise total interest even when the rate drops.

TABLE 9

Diversification and Risk Management

Diversification is the closest thing investing has to a free lunch: spreading money across assets that don't all move together smooths out the ride without necessarily lowering returns. These principles cover the dimensions you can spread along, asset class, geography, sector, plus the habits, like rebalancing and staying invested, that keep risk in check over a full market cycle.

Principle	Example	Description
Asset Class Diversification	60% stocks, 30% bonds, 10% real estate	• Spread investments across asset types with different risk/return profiles • reduces portfolio volatility when assets move independently • lowers company and sector specific (unsystematic) risk, but cannot eliminate market wide (systematic) risk.
Geographic Diversification	70% U.S., 30% international stocks	• Hold both domestic and international investments • reduces exposure tied to one country's economy • captures global growth opportunities beyond home market.
Sector Diversification	Growth sectors like technology and industrials tend to lead in an expanding economy, while defensive sectors like utilities and consumer staples tend to hold up better in a slowdown	• Avoid concentration in a single industry • different sectors perform differently across the economic cycle • prevents a single sector's downturn from devastating the whole portfolio.
Correlation	Large-cap U.S. stock funds often correlate near +0.9 with the broad market, while government bonds can turn negative when stocks sell off	• Statistical relationship between asset movements • low or negative correlation improves diversification benefits • bonds often, but not always, rise when stocks fall.
Rebalancing	60/40 portfolio drifts to 70/30 after stocks rally, sell some stocks to restore the 60/40 mix	• Restore target allocation by selling outperformers and buying underperformers • enforces buy-low-sell-high discipline • typically done annually or when drift exceeds a set percentage.
Market Timing vs Time in Market	A fully invested S&P 500 portfolio returned 10% annualized from 2005 to 2025, but missing just the 10 best days in that stretch cut the return to 5.6%	• Staying invested beats attempting to time entry and exit • missing a handful of the market's best days devastates long run returns • consistent investing historically outperforms waiting for a "perfect" moment.
Sequence of Returns Risk	Negative returns in the early years of retirement, combined with ongoing withdrawals, can deplete a portfolio that would have lasted fine under a different order of the same average returns	• Timing of returns matters during the withdrawal phase • losses early in retirement combined with withdrawals can permanently damage a portfolio's sustainability • distinct from ordinary market risk, since it is about the ORDER returns happen in, not just their average.

TABLE 10

Investing Costs and Fees

Fees look trivial as a single percentage, but they quietly compound against you the same way returns compound for you. A 1% annual drag can swallow a large share of your portfolio over a working lifetime, so learning to spot expense ratios, loads, and advisory fees is one of the few guaranteed ways to keep more of what you earn.

Fee Type	Example	Description
Expense Ratio	0.03% on \$100K = \$30/year	• Annual fee as percentage of assets • automatically deducted from fund returns • 0.10% or less for index funds, 0.50%+ for active funds • compounds significantly over decades.
Load Fees	5% front-load on \$10,000 = \$500 upfront	• Sales charges on mutual fund purchases or sales • front-load charged upfront, back-load on sale • the fund's separate annual expense ratio still applies on top of any load • avoid load funds, no-load alternatives widely available.

Fee Type	Example	Description
12b-1 Fees	0.25% annual marketing fee	• Marketing and distribution costs in mutual funds • included in expense ratio • ETFs do not charge 12b-1 fees • a fund advertised as no-load can still carry a 12b-1 fee.
Transaction Fees	\$0 to \$25+ per stock trade depending on the broker	• Brokerage charges per buy/sell order • many brokers now offer commission-free trades • even commission-free trades still carry a bid-ask spread cost • still apply to some mutual funds and options.
Advisory Fees	1% AUM fee on \$500K = \$5,000/year	• Financial advisor charges percentage of assets under management, billed on an ongoing yearly basis • robo-advisors are typically the cheaper option, human advisors typically cost more • evaluate the planning, tax, or coaching value provided against the dollar cost, rather than assuming any fee is automatically good or bad.
Expense Ratio Impact	\$100,000 at 4% growth for 20 years: a 1.5% expense ratio costs about \$55,000 versus paying no fee at all	• Seemingly small percentages compound to massive differences • the longer you hold a fund, the more its expense ratio matters, not less • prioritize low-cost funds.

TABLE 11

Retirement Planning Milestones

Retirement planning runs on a calendar of specific ages, each unlocking a benefit or imposing a rule: from catch-up contributions at 50, to penalty-free withdrawals at 59½, to required distributions at 73. Knowing these dates ahead of time lets you sequence withdrawals and Social Security claims to your advantage rather than scrambling when each one arrives.

Milestone	Example	Description
Age 50: Catch-Up Contributions	401(k) \$24,500 + \$8,000 catch-up = \$32,500	• Additional \$8,000 for 401(k), \$1,100 for IRA allowed once you turn 50, based on your age at the end of the calendar year, not your exact birthday • accelerates savings as retirement approaches • 2026 limits.
Ages 60-63: Super Catch-Up	401(k) catch-up jumps to \$11,250 instead of \$8,000 (2026)	• A SECURE 2.0 provision gives this narrow four-year age band a bigger catch-up than the standard 50+ amount • applies to 401(k), 403(b), and governmental 457 plans; SIMPLE plans get a smaller \$5,250 version • drops back to the regular \$8,000 catch-up at 64.
Age 59½: Penalty-Free Withdrawals	Withdraw IRA funds without 10% penalty	• Earliest age for penalty-free withdrawals from retirement accounts, this makes withdrawals optional, not mandatory • income taxes still apply to pre-tax accounts • Roth principal always penalty-free.
Age 62: Early Social Security	Claim \$1,200/month vs \$1,700 at FRA	• Earliest Social Security claiming age, with a permanently reduced benefit of up to 25-30% for those with a full retirement age of 67 • locks in lower lifetime payments • rarely optimal unless health issues shorten expected lifespan.
Age 65: Medicare Eligibility	Enroll in Parts A, B, D within 7-month window	• Federal health insurance begins • Part A (hospital) typically free, Part B (medical) \$202.90/month (2026) • 10% surcharge for each 12 months enrollment is delayed without creditable coverage, lasting as long as you keep Part B.
Age 67: Full Retirement Age (FRA)	Born 1960+: claim full \$1,700 benefit	• Age for 100% of your own calculated Social Security benefit, with no early-claiming reduction • varies by birth year • FRA is 67 for those born 1960 or later.
Age 70: Maximum Social Security	Delayed credits: \$1,700 to \$2,108 (+24%)	• Delayed retirement credits keep adding about 8% a year from FRA to age 70 • credits stop building once you turn 70, so there is no benefit to waiting past it • often optimal for higher earners and those expecting a long retirement.

Milestone	Example	Description
Age 73: Required Minimum Distributions	\$500K IRA ÷ 26.5 factor = \$18,868 RMD	- Mandatory withdrawals from tax-deferred accounts begin - calculated by account balance divided by an IRS life-expectancy factor 25% excise tax on any amount not withdrawn on time, reduced to 10% if corrected within two years - age increases to 75 in 2033.
4% Safe Withdrawal Rate	\$1M portfolio to \$40K first year	- Widely used guideline for sustainable retirement withdrawals, mathematically the same idea as the 25x rule viewed from the withdrawal side - adjust the dollar amount annually for inflation - based on roughly a 30-year retirement - some researchers argue a more conservative rate is safer for very long retirements, though there is no single agreed-upon replacement number.
Retirement Savings by Age 30	1x annual salary: \$60K salary = \$60K saved	- Aspirational benchmark of one year's salary saved by 30, based on saving steadily from age 25 and retiring around 67 - roughly 3x by 40, 6x by 50, 10x by 67, and the multiple itself shifts if you plan to retire earlier or later - a general guidepost, not a personalized target.
25x Annual Expenses Rule	Need \$50K/year, target a \$1.25M portfolio	- FIRE movement guideline: multiply annual expenses by 25 to estimate a retirement nest egg - the same math as the 4% withdrawal rate, just viewed from the savings side instead of the spending side.

TABLE 12

Social Security and Medicare

Two government programs form the backbone of most retirements, and small decisions about each have large, permanent consequences. The terms here (PIA, the earnings test, COLA, spousal benefits, and the alphabet of Medicare parts) are what you need to time your claim, coordinate as a couple, and avoid the penalties and surcharges that catch people off guard.

Concept	Example	Description
Primary Insurance Amount (PIA)	Average indexed earnings → \$1,976/month	Full retirement age benefit calculated from highest 35 years of wage indexed earnings, run through a 90%/32%/15% bend point formula - claiming early reduces, delaying increases permanent monthly amount - the formula is progressive, so lower lifetime earners get a much bigger share of their pay replaced than high earners.
Earnings Test	Under FRA: \$24,480 earnings limit in 2026	- If claiming before FRA while still working, \$1 withheld per \$2 over the \$24,480 limit; \$1 per \$3 over \$65,160 in the year FRA is reached - withheld amounts are not lost, they raise your monthly benefit once you reach FRA - no limit once FRA reached.
COLA (Cost of Living Adjustment)	2.8% increase in 2026 benefits	Annual inflation adjustment set automatically from the CPI-W, a price index built on younger working households 2026 COLA is 2.8% - can lag the actual inflation retirees feel, especially healthcare costs, so a raise can still be eaten up by rising premiums.
Spousal Benefits	Claim 50% of spouse's PIA at FRA	- Lower earning spouse receives up to 50% of higher earner's Primary Insurance Amount, only in full at FRA - reduced to about 32.5% if claimed at 62 - Social Security pays the larger of your own benefit or the spousal benefit, never both combined.
Medicare Part B Premium	\$202.90/month standard 2026 premium	Monthly charge for medical insurance, usually deducted from Social Security - IRMAA surcharges apply for higher incomes - Part A is premium free only with about 10 years of Medicare tax payments by you or a spouse, otherwise it also has a monthly premium.

Concept	Example	Description
Medicare Part D	Prescription drug plan \$30-100/month	• Prescription coverage avoiding late enrollment penalty • plans vary by formulary and cost • late enrollment penalty is 1% of the national base beneficiary premium per month delayed past initial eligibility, added to your premium for as long as you're enrolled.
IRMAA (Income-Related Adjustment)	Income >\$109K single: extra \$81.20 to \$487/month Part B (2026)	• Surcharges for higher earners on Medicare Parts B and D • based on your Modified Adjusted Gross Income from the tax return filed 2 years prior, not current income • a cliff surcharge, so \$1 over the threshold triggers the higher tier; a one time income spike like a Roth conversion can trigger it two years later.
Medigap (Supplement Insurance)	Plan G covers copays, deductibles	• Private insurance filling Medicare gaps • standardized plans (A-N) • covers out-of-pocket costs Original Medicare doesn't • cannot be used with Medicare Advantage, you must pick one or the other.

TABLE 13

Investment Strategies

Beyond what you buy and how you split it lies the question of *how* you pick: the philosophy guiding your decisions. These approaches range from the passive simplicity of buy-and-hold index investing to the more active disciplines of value, growth, and dividend investing, each with its own evidence base and demands on your time. CheatGrid's Investing 101 cheat sheet is the place to put any of these into practice on a first portfolio.

Strategy	Example	Description
Buy and Hold	Purchase VOO, hold 30+ years	• Long-term ownership regardless of market fluctuations • minimizes taxes and transaction costs • time in market historically beats market timing.
Value Investing	Buy stocks with low P/E, trading below book value	• Focus on undervalued companies trading below intrinsic worth • requires fundamental analysis • Warren Buffett's legendary approach.
Growth Investing	Technology stocks with 20%+ earnings growth	• Companies with above-average growth potential • typically higher P/E ratios • more volatile but potentially higher returns.
Dividend Growth Investing	Dividend Aristocrats: 25+ years increases	• Focus on companies consistently raising dividends • compounds income over time • provides growing cash flow in retirement.
Index Fund Investing	VTI total market, VOO S&P 500	• Passive strategy tracking market indexes • ultra-low costs • SPIVA's latest scorecard found no category, across domestic, international, or fixed income, where a majority of active managers beat their benchmark over 15 years • ideal for most investors.
Asset Class Rotation	Shift to value stocks in recession expectations	• Tactical changes between stocks, bonds, commodities based on economic cycle • requires accurate timing • often underperforms staying invested.
Tax Loss Harvesting	Sell loser to offset \$10K gain, buy similar fund	• Sell losing positions to offset gains • reduces tax liability • reinvest in similar asset to maintain allocation • beware 30-day wash sale rule.

TABLE 14

Tax Strategies

The order and timing of your moves can save more than the returns themselves, especially as you transition from earning to drawing down. These strategies, Roth conversions, harvesting gains and losses in the right years, charitable distributions, and account sequencing, are about deliberately controlling which dollars get taxed and when, rather than leaving it to chance.

Strategy	Example	Description
Roth Conversion	Convert \$50K Traditional IRA to Roth, pay tax now	• Transfer pre-tax IRA to Roth IRA paying ordinary income tax • future growth and withdrawals tax-free • strategic in low-income years or before RMDs.
Roth Conversion Ladder	Convert \$30K annually for 5 years to Roth	• Systematic multi-year conversions staying within lower tax brackets • each conversion has its own 5-year clock and is accessible penalty-free once that clock ends • enables early retirement withdrawals.
Tax-Advantaged Account Sequencing	Fill: 401(k) match → HSA → Roth IRA → max 401(k)	• Prioritize accounts by tax benefit • employer match (free money) first, then triple-tax HSA, then Roth, then additional tax-deferred • maximizes tax efficiency.
Capital Gains Harvesting	Realize gains at 0% long-term rate	• Sell appreciated assets in low-income years at favorable 0% or 15% long-term capital gains rates • reset cost basis higher • the gap years between retirement and RMDs are often ideal, when income tends to be lowest.
Qualified Charitable Distributions (QCD)	Donate \$50K RMD directly to charity	• Direct IRA transfers to charity after age 70½ • satisfies RMD, excludes from taxable income • more beneficial than itemized deduction for many, since it works even with the standard deduction.
Wash Sale Rule	Sell stock at loss, can't rebuy 30 days	• Cannot claim loss if substantially identical security bought 30 days before or after sale • disallowed loss added to replacement cost basis • doesn't apply to crypto currently, since the IRS treats it as property, not a security.
Opportunity Zone Investing	Defer capital gains investing in OZ fund	• Defer capital gains by investing in designated economically distressed areas • a 10-year hold lets the fund's own appreciation go untaxed, but the original deferred gain is still eventually included • complex rules.
SECURE Act 2.0 Changes	RMD age increased from 72 to 73 (75 in 2033)	• Recent legislation increased RMD starting age, added a higher catch-up tier for ages 60 through 63, and allows 529-to-Roth rollovers • reduces forced distributions allowing longer tax-deferred growth.

TABLE 15

Estate Planning Basics

Estate planning isn't only for the wealthy, it's the paperwork that decides who controls your money and your medical care if you can't, and where everything goes when you're gone. A will, a trust, powers of attorney, and up to date beneficiary designations work together to spare your family probate, guesswork, and avoidable taxes.

Document	Example	Description
Last Will and Testament	Designate assets to children, name executor	• Legal document specifying asset distribution upon death • names guardian for minor children • requires probate • foundational estate planning document everyone needs.

Document	Example	Description
Revocable Living Trust	Transfer home title to trust, avoid probate	- Trust holding assets avoiding probate process - maintains control during life - private (unlike wills) - can be changed or revoked - faster distribution to heirs.
Beneficiary Designations	IRA: spouse 100%, children contingent	- Named recipients on retirement accounts and life insurance - override will provisions - keep current after marriages, divorces, births - review annually.
Durable Power of Attorney	Spouse manages finances if incapacitated	- Legal authority for someone to manage financial affairs during incapacity "durable" means it survives incapacity, unlike a regular power of attorney which ends - essential for avoiding guardianship or conservatorship proceedings.
Healthcare Power of Attorney	Designate medical decision maker	- Grants authority to make healthcare decisions if unable - separate from financial POA - also called healthcare proxy - coordinates with living will.
Living Will (Advance Directive)	Document end of life treatment preferences	- Specifies medical treatment wishes for terminal or permanently unconscious conditions - reduces family burden of difficult decisions - states your own wishes in writing, while a healthcare power of attorney names a person to decide.
Annual Gift Tax Exclusion	\$19,000 per recipient in 2026, \$38,000 for a married couple splitting gifts	- Gifts up to this amount per recipient, per year don't count against the lifetime estate/gift exemption or require a gift tax return - a simple way to move wealth to heirs gradually while you're still alive.
Estate Tax Exemption	2026: \$15M individual, \$30M couple (with portability)	Amount exempt from federal estate tax - estates exceeding threshold taxed up to 40% - most estates avoid federal tax with current high exemptions - portability lets a surviving spouse add a deceased spouse's unused exemption - some states levy their own estate tax at lower thresholds.
TOD/POD Accounts	Bank account Transfer-On-Death or Payable-On-Death to daughter	- Accounts with Transfer-On-Death or Payable-On-Death designations - assets pass directly to beneficiary avoiding probate - beneficiary has no access or management rights before the account holder's death - simple, single-account probate avoidance tool, not a substitute for incapacity planning.

TABLE 16

Insurance Types

Insurance is how you protect the wealth you're building from a single catastrophic event: a death, a disability, a lawsuit, a fire. Each type here covers a specific risk, and the recurring lesson is to insure the things that would genuinely wreck your finances (lost income, liability, major care) rather than over paying for bundled investment-and-insurance products. CheatGrid's Insurance and Protecting Your Income cheat sheet goes deeper on choosing coverage amounts and shopping for a policy.

Type	Example	Description
Term Life Insurance	\$500K 20-year term, \$40/month	Pure death benefit for a specified period - no cash value - dramatically cheaper than permanent coverage - ideal during working years with dependents.
Whole Life Insurance	\$250K policy, \$200/month, cash value growth	Permanent coverage with a cash value component - guaranteed death benefit as long as premiums keep being paid - much higher premiums than term - marketed as a forced savings feature, though its growth typically trails a diversified investment portfolio over time.

Type	Example	Description
Disability Insurance	60% income replacement if unable to work	- Replaces a portion of income during disability - own-occupation vs any-occupation definitions - waiting period before benefits start - most long-term claims come from illness, not accidents.
Long-Term Care Insurance	\$3,000/month nursing care, 3-year benefit	- Covers extended custodial care at home or in a facility, which Medicare does not pay for - purchase age 50-65 optimal - expensive but protects savings from long care costs.
Umbrella Insurance	\$1M coverage above auto/home limits	Excess liability protection beyond underlying auto or home policies - covers lawsuits and injury claims - relatively inexpensive for the amount of coverage it adds - worth considering for anyone with meaningful assets, income, or added risk (a pool, a teen driver), not only the wealthy.
Health Insurance	\$500/month premium, \$5,000 deductible, 80/20	- Covers medical expenses and protects against medical bankruptcy - premiums, deductibles, copays, and an out-of-pocket maximum that caps your yearly cost sharing - employer-sponsored or marketplace.
Auto Insurance	100/300/100 liability coverage	Required liability protection plus optional comprehensive and collision coverage - state minimums are a legal floor, not a safety net, and are often insufficient - being underinsured leaves your personal assets exposed after a serious accident.
Homeowners/Renters Insurance	Dwelling + personal property + liability	- Protects home structure, possessions, and liability - replacement cost vs actual cash value - renters need their own policy, since a landlord's insurance only repairs the building, not a tenant's belongings.

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